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Councillor Bernie Muir
Councillor Kieran Persand
Horton Ward, Epsom & Ewell Borough Council
By email

[ ] August 2026

Dear Councillor Muir and Councillor Persand

Cumulative Green Belt change across the historic Horton estate — a request for your support

We write on behalf of Oak Glade Management Limited and Cuddington Glade Management Limited, which together represent the twenty-eight households of Oak Glade and Cuddington Glade, off Chertsey Lane in your ward. Both communities occupy former Manor Hospital land at the southern edge of the historic Horton estate.

We are writing to ask for your support on a single, specific point about the emerging Local Plan. We are not asking you to oppose housing or care provision, and we are not suggesting that the Council has acted improperly. We are asking that one question be put to officers, and answered.

The point

The historic Horton Hospital estate comprises five former hospital sites extending to 204.29 hectares, every hectare of which is presently designated Metropolitan Green Belt. The Submission Local Plan proposes to remove 82.27 hectares from the Green Belt through revised Major Developed Site inset boundaries. The figures below are the Council's own.

Former hospital site	Site area (ha)	Proposed inset (ha)	Proportion
West Park	34.95	25.60	73.2%
St Ebba's	26.19	16.14	61.6%
Livingstone Park	38.92	14.63	37.6%
Clarendon Park	45.09	12.19	27.0%
Manor Park	59.14	13.71	23.2%
Total	**204.29**	**82.27**	**40.3%**

Source: Epsom & Ewell Borough Council Green Belt evidence base and Submission Local Plan.

The two sites beside our communities — HOR001 (0.52 ha, now the subject of a planning application for a three-storey, 70-bed care home) and HOR004 (1.11 ha, proposed for around fifty dwellings) — are additional to that total.

Each of these changes is assessed separately, in separate documents, against separate tests. **We have not been able to identify any published document in which their combined effect is assessed as a single question.**

Why this should concern the Council, not only us

The Council itself identified the risk. Its site assessment work published in December 2024 concluded that neither HOR001 nor HOR004 demonstrated the exceptional circumstances required for release from the Green Belt. It described one site as "rather small", with "limited benefit from the quantum of development" against the impact on openness, and warned that both were awkwardly shaped parcels vulnerable to incremental infill — characterising the risk as the "slow ebbing away of small areas of Green Belt".

Eighteen months later, both sites are proposed for release. The sites themselves have not changed: their area, their protected trees, their semi-natural grassland, their shape and their relationship to Epsom Common are as recorded then. National planning policy has changed materially, and the Council is fully entitled to revisit its judgement in the light of it. What we have been unable to find is the site-specific reasoning that connects the December 2024 conclusions to the current position.

There is also a test the Inspector herself set. Following the Matter 4 hearing on 1 October 2025, the Council agreed to provide further information demonstrating that first consideration had been given to land which is previously developed and/or well served by public transport. HOR001 appears to satisfy neither limb: it has never been built on, and it lies some twenty minutes' walk from Epsom station on limited bus routes. If that is right, the question follows: which land was given first consideration ahead of it?

What we have already done

We appeared at the Examination hearing on 2 July 2026. We have examined the published Green Belt topic papers, the site assessments, the Sustainability Appraisal and its addendum, the Habitats Regulations Assessment addendum, and the transport and infrastructure evidence. We asked the Council directly, through the Programme Officer, on two occasions in July, to identify where the relevant assessments are recorded. We have received no response identifying that material.

If such an assessment exists and we have simply not found it, we would be glad to be directed to it.

What we are asking of you

- That you ask officers, formally, where the combined effect of the proposed Green Belt changes across the historic Horton estate is assessed in a single document — and if it is not, that you press for that assessment to be carried out and published before the changes are confirmed.
- That you ask officers what the "inconsistencies and inaccuracies" in the original site assessments of HOR001 and HOR004 were, and where the revised assessment methodology is set out.
- That you ask whether HOR001 is previously developed land, whether it is well served by public transport, and if neither, which land was given first consideration ahead of it.

We are asking for assessment, not refusal. If the combined effect proves acceptable, the assessment will show it and the Plan will be the stronger for having done the work. If it is not, that is better established before adoption than afterwards, since Green Belt once released is not recovered.

We would add that this reaches beyond two small sites. If parcels of half a hectare can be released without a cumulative assessment because each is individually modest, the same reasoning is available for the next parcel, and the one after — which is precisely the mechanism the Council's own officers identified.

Enclosure, and an offer

We enclose a Planning Evidence Review prepared on behalf of the two companies and published on 5 August 2026. It introduces no new technical evidence: it draws on the Council's published evidence base, national policy, and official copies of registered title obtained from HM Land Registry. Every figure in this letter is taken from the Council's own published material, and Chapter 5 sets them out with their sources.

We would be very glad to meet you, together or separately, at your convenience, to talk this through or to walk the site with you. We appreciate how much of your time these matters take, and we are grateful for your consideration.

Yours faithfully

Julian Downing
On behalf of Oak Glade Management Limited and Cuddington Glade Management Limited